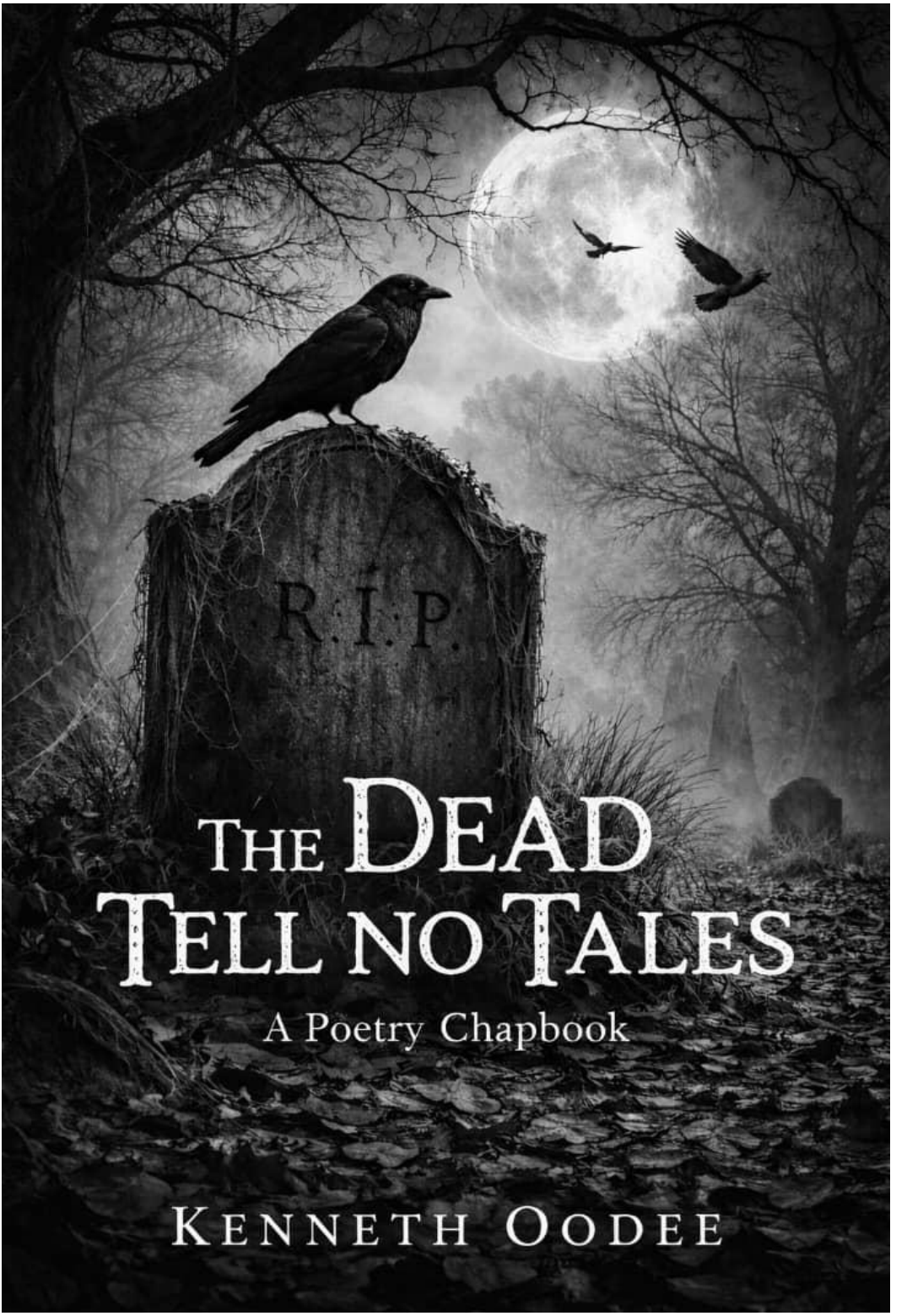

The Dead Tell No Tales

A Poetry Chapbook

Kenneth Oodee

SYNOPSIS

“The Dead Tell No Tales” Is a reflective poetry collection that meditates on silence, memory, and the limitations of wisdom after death. Kenneth Oodee explores the tension between humanity’s desperate search for truth and the finality of the grave, revealing how secrets, regrets, and unspoken words are buried and alongside the dead. Through haunting imagery and philosophical inquiry, the collection questions the value of wisdom that arrives too late to be lived, if only there were a second chance, but there isn’t.

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MEDITATIONS FROM THE GRAVEYARD

People never care until you are resting in peace or in pieces
Their love is creamed, clothed
in greed and pretense
We have always known,
yet the hypocrisy was comforting
like hoping for true love
while knowing they are only flirting

People come and go
Most times, it is how they leave
that lives forever
We receive thousands of roses in death,
As if we were gardeners
Yet alive, not even a single rose
Were we granted to hold

Life is a course
Humans are the curse
There is nothing loving
In a resentful world,
Nothing melodious
In a hateful word

No wonder the truest life
Is the life after life
These are the thoughts and meditations from the graveyard.

THE ILLUSION OF OWNERSHIP

They never grow tired of sleeping
They rest, and by extension, rest on
Some in peace, some in chaos
It all depends on the life before

Some are happy, some are sad
It all depends on the destination after
Their beds are beautifully furnished
Yet some lived wretched in poverty

They are, by far, the wealthiest
Yet many lived lives of abject scarcity
How do we explain those who died at twenty
Yet were not buried until forty?

How do we explain those who owned a hundred houses
But were laid in a box smaller than half a home?
This is the mystery reality never tells us
The world is ours
Yet in truth, we owned nothing.

THE ECONOMY OF THE DEAD

The graveyard runs out of room
For the dead hold thousands of secrets
The world is filled with riches
Yet the graveyard is filled with wealth

Talents buried into eternity
Birds perch upon every tomb
Cobwebs curtain forgotten glory
Where time stands still, yet ticks consume

Treasures fine, beyond all measure
No beauty born of gold or sight
An invisible crowd in silent motion
Walking through eternal night

Some arrive humble, unnamed by history
Some crowned by legacy and pride
Endless tales, forever untold
For dead men take their stories inside.

THE MERCY OF THE GRAVE

On the road to the cemetery lies scattered pain,
Nothing to wash it away, not even the rain
In the graveyard rests a man, still alive
Striving with every breath he has left to survive

Clothed in misery and crowned by death
To others, not a single wound was felt
For he lived a life of unfiltered wickedness
Killing and stealing, driven by blind ambitiousness

Greed and covetousness were his idols
Without conscience, he committed the abominable
Bad intentions, followed by worse decisions
Evil became both his fame and addiction

To save humanity in moments of urgency
Sometimes, even death is mercy.

OH DEATH!

Oh death
The bitter taste of life
Your hunger, born of desperation never rests.
You are the end of living
Yet from the very beginning
You trouble us like a restless wife

Oh death
You are never satisfied
Your fleeting desires never quenches
Either you have killed,
Or you are killing,
Or you are already on your way.
No holidays
No remorse
Not even a moment of chill

Oh death
The Sinner's Nightmare
You circle your victims
Like a lover in a secret affair
You are full of rage
And emptied of mercy
Blooming in tragedy
Without apology

Oh death
Sometimes you are selective in your wickedness

The innocent remain
Your easiest victims
You justify yourself without morality,
and in doing so
become your own abomination.

Yours Truly 🌹

THE HEIGHT BELOW

They have their opinions
They have their suggestions
They have their pain
And yes, their stories too

They scream the loudest, yet are never heard
In the sphere of time, their invisibility rhymes
So many wise words, dismissed as foolish by the living
For even chaff is deemed more valuable by comparison

Their stories are braided with pain and glory
Mixed with shame and folly alike
This is the highest height their wisdom can attain
Beneath us lies the peak of their remaining fame

Their beauty shines only in darkness
For the dead hold no growth.

FOOTPRINTS OF REVERENCE

The echoes of an audible silence
Escorted by a solemn ambience
A cemetery clothed in incense
The ground littered with condolences

Crested upon the tombs are epitaphs
Somehow, we all earn our autographs
At last, life becomes fair
Even when, while she lived
We never shared a good affair

The evening wind drops rusty leaves
And on that red carpet linger ancient beliefs
"Respect for ancestors"
Words not borrowed from poet or author

This is spiritual and cultural admiration
A footprint passed down
From generation to generation.

AFFECTION AFTER DEATH

Some call it the graveyard,
Some call it a garden of roses
Endless gifts of flowers
One way or another,
Its occupants were once lovers

For romance has no limits
Neither does remembrance keep a date
We are inspired by memories
Compelled by the legacies left behind

Some we loved, and some we hated
It does not matter now; they are late
For sometimes death breeds love
And sometimes the lives we lived inspire hate

Even though we often care too late
Why must we truly deserve flowers
Only in death?

WHAT THE DEAD REMEMBER

They no longer remember their enemies
Nor do they recall their favorite pursuits
Only their legacies and how they lived
Their destination, and what they failed to become

The pain of unlived lives
The fear of what the world might have said
The kindness they could not extend
The love and generosity withheld

The world is overly congested
Yet hollow of truth and originality
Everything is an illusion
Even the sanest mind is void of true knowledge.

THE BOUNDARY OF TIME

As the night turned black,
The world returned
Back to before creation,
When reality existed without form

The dead littered the streets
The wind grew strict with shivers
Echoes rose from whispered creatures
Yet nature's realm remained orderly

Covered in fog stood the cemetery
One after another, they stepped out
Like a pageantry of the unseen
It was their time to sell and trade

Their time to run the economy
They live outside of time
Yet the boundaries of life
Remain governed by it.

THEY LIVE AHEAD

There is no electricity, yet they see ahead
No banks to save in, yet their treasures are never lost
No good roads, yet no accidents occur
No markets stand, yet trade moves in order

No schools, still wisdom and knowledge flourish
No church, yet their bones dangle in praise and worship
No offices, no leaders, yet they work, respecting hierarchy
No hospitals exist, for their health is eternal

Their faith walks ahead of deeds
Their fate stretches beyond their lives in the dark
They sleep within the tomb, yet live in the afterlife
Like humans, they do not live in the present

they live in the future
Their home has no walls
even when their boxes
limit their shadows on the floor.

THE CURRICULUM OF DEATH

The entire knowledge of life
Lies six feet below
Human knowledge is foolishness
Corrupted and bloated with pride

"The dead tell no tales"
Yet silence harbours wisdom
The living despise silence
Yet noise utters foolishness

The ironies of life are alarming
As the scales of oxymoron dangle through the night
Written on the scroll of life
Are stories that succeed death

Written in the scroll of death
Are stories that precede life.

GRAVES WITHOUT STONES

Some are buried beneath the sea,
Where mortal eyes can scarcely see
Some are buried in the ground
Where even rising waters cannot drown

Some are buried in the forest,
Hoping with their ancestors, they may rest
Some are buried in the desert
Where their treasures lie far from reach

Some are buried in foreign lands,
Far from familiar tongues and hands
Some are buried in graveyards
Known, named, and marked

Yet there is no better place to be laid
Than within the heart
For the heart is a home
Where we can truly live forever
And by the way,
This poem is not about death.

TEARS ON EVERY STONE

The lonely cemetery whispers aloud,
While noisy occupants lie silent, yet proud
The hearts of immortals, no tears, no devotion,
The minds of immortals, endless in motion

Corpses drool upon ancient beds
Tombstones serve as pillows for weary heads
There is guilt in every brittle bone
There are tears upon every stone

Memories buried beneath regret
Karma arrives to collect each debt
The echoes rise from the graveyard deep
The raven's cry disturbs their sleep

The value and worth of death remain
The price and cost of life—our pain.

CANTICLE OF SHADOWS

The mighty wind runs in circles,
Ancient fallen leaves begin to rustle
Bones stretch quietly on their beds
The long, unbroken slumber of the dead

Shadows linger on every stone
Together in rest, yet still alone
Whistling pines mourn in melody
Pouring their grief into rhapsody

Spirits linger, hovering around
Gathering memories from the ground
Twilight devours the dying light
Crows and owls speak in turns, and that's alright

Every moment, every minute
The dead reject a banquet of the living.

EQUAL DUST

A yard filled with sin and righteousness,
Blood and tears
Wisdom and illiteracy
Truth and lies

Pain and happiness
The rich and the poor
The haves and the have-nots
Beauty and boldness

The humble and the proud
The fearful and the confident
The good and the bad
The young and the old

The blessed and the unfortunate
White and Black
Straight and gay
Here stands the wealthiest place on Earth.

FROM WOMB TO TOMB

From the womb, we are wrapped in darkness,
Taught how to live, yet told to mind our business
Given identities by names we never chose
All we hear is, “It has been this way long ago.”

We are called by ancient names of ancestors
Yet told we are newborns, what a soothing lie.
They say we are free to become whoever we want
But when we do, we’re reckless, nonchalant

The world itself feels like a trap, a prison
You’re either an outcast or an obedient citizen
Suffocating beneath the illusion of freedom
Watched by cameras, bound by constitution

Down to the tomb, we remain clothed in darkness
There is no freedom in this world.

IN THE END

"Let us tell the truth, shall we?
That nothing truly lasts at all
So, give more love than you acquire possessions
For in the end, they all become ashes

Trust nothing and no one to be your god
There is nothing in life except life itself
The anger that consumes you will eventually reduce you
The pride that clothes you will also limit you

Life is meaningless without purpose
Purpose is void without its source
Its source is the road to its Creator
This is the only journey in life

There is so much time, yet there is no time
Some live in the morning,
Some at noon,
And some make it to the night.
Yet only two things remain constant
Regret and reward
And, by extension, a little of both"?

ADIEU

There are thousands of lonely graves,
Filled with the foolish and the brave
Covered in darkness, buried in lies
Still starving for truth on the beds where they lie

In life, they tasted pain and shame
Moments they betrayed, and times they were blamed
They were crucified for choosing the true
And their only reward was a final adieu
Some souls still suffer

Night after night, their spirits cry out
Till eternity, some wonder what death was about
Their blood flowing endlessly through corridors of time
"Gone too soon" has learned their names, turned grief into rhyme

Some souls are too gentle to survive the living
Some souls die too often in their search for life.

SPEAK NO EVIL OF THE DEAD

In reverence, speak no evil,
Neither in remembrance, let not our words be cruel
The wind carries away our echoes
Down to the earth where they decompose

And time keeps her records for eternity
The dead have no pressing necessity
Just as the living have their messengers
So too the dead, in hierarchy, have their messengers

Do not speak ill of the dead
Their troubles and peace have long been laid
Their sins are buried beneath the dust of earth
And in reminiscence, the grave holds no mirth

So let our grace and mercy intercede,
For the grave is soft, but judgment is harsh indeed.

THE DEAD TELL NO TALES

"The dead tell no tales,"
Neither do they reveal details
Every secret rest in their legacies
There lie their truths and their fallacies

"The dead tell no tales,"
Buried with every unspoken word
This is one tragedy death entails
One limitation of the graveyard

"The dead tell no tales,"
Yet humans are desperate to hear
Like searching for a river in the desert
Foolishness, indeed, inseparable from man

"The dead tell no tales,"
No wonder the cemetery is full of wisdom
Perhaps the most useless form of wisdom of all
For what is wisdom, if it cannot be applied?